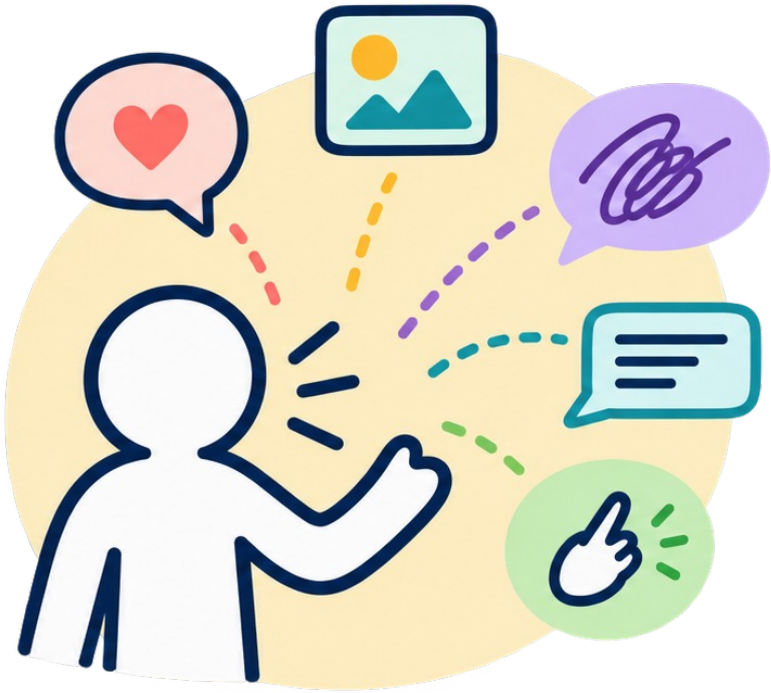




Early Career Teachers · Session 3

Autistic Experience at School:

**Communication, Connection
and Identity**



Communication





Understanding and expressing

How much someone speaks does not tell us how much they understand.

Understanding

Information coming in

Spoken words



Visual or written



Demonstration



Gesture and context



Expressing

Messages going out

Speech



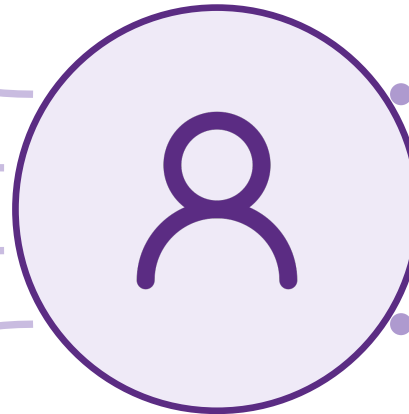
AAC

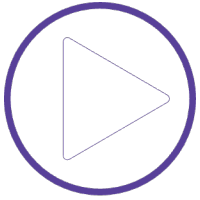


Writing or typing



Gesture, sign and movement





Communication experiences

What stood out to you about what supported communication?



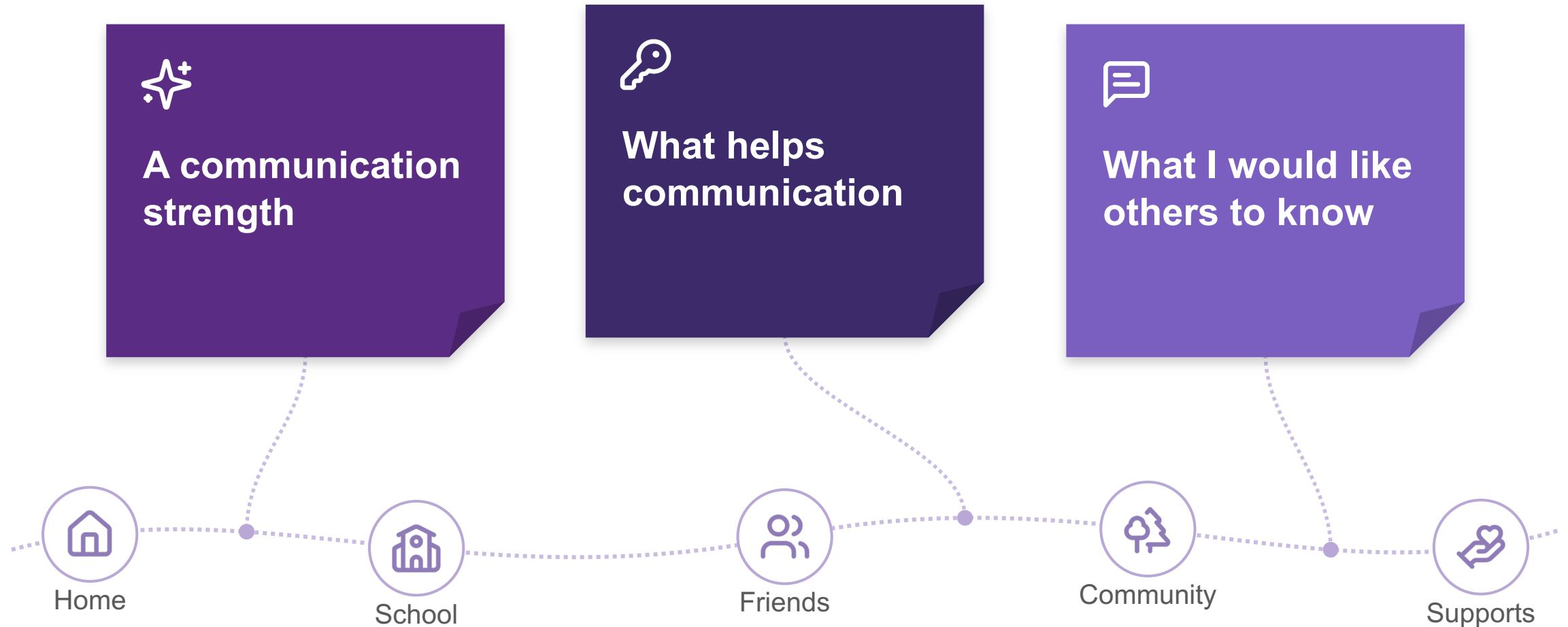
Who is part of the communication network?



Add one person or place.

You can return to the rest later.

What should travel between people and places?



How can we support communication?

1

CLEAR COMMUNICATION

Use familiar words.
One idea or step at a time.

2

PROCESSING TIME

Pause. Give time to
understand and respond.

3

VISUAL SUPPORTS

Show information as well
as saying it.

The right support depends on the person and the moment.

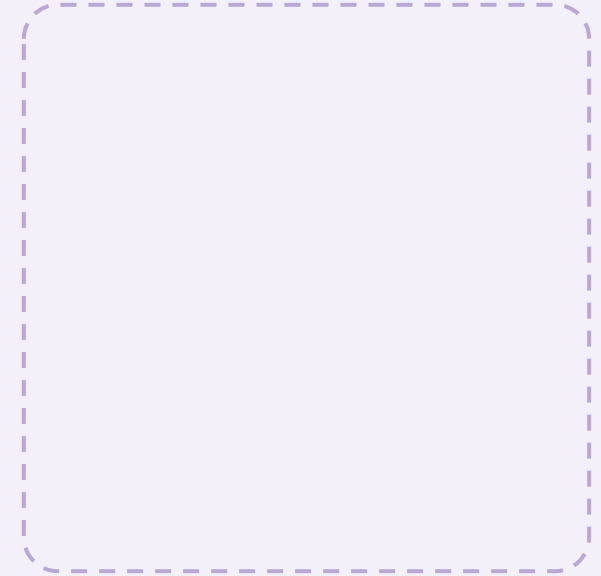
What are visual supports?



How much time is left?



What do I do next?

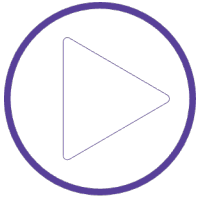


What is happening today?

Information you can see and come back to.

Double Empathy





Being social



Social Interactions

Family

School

Community

Online

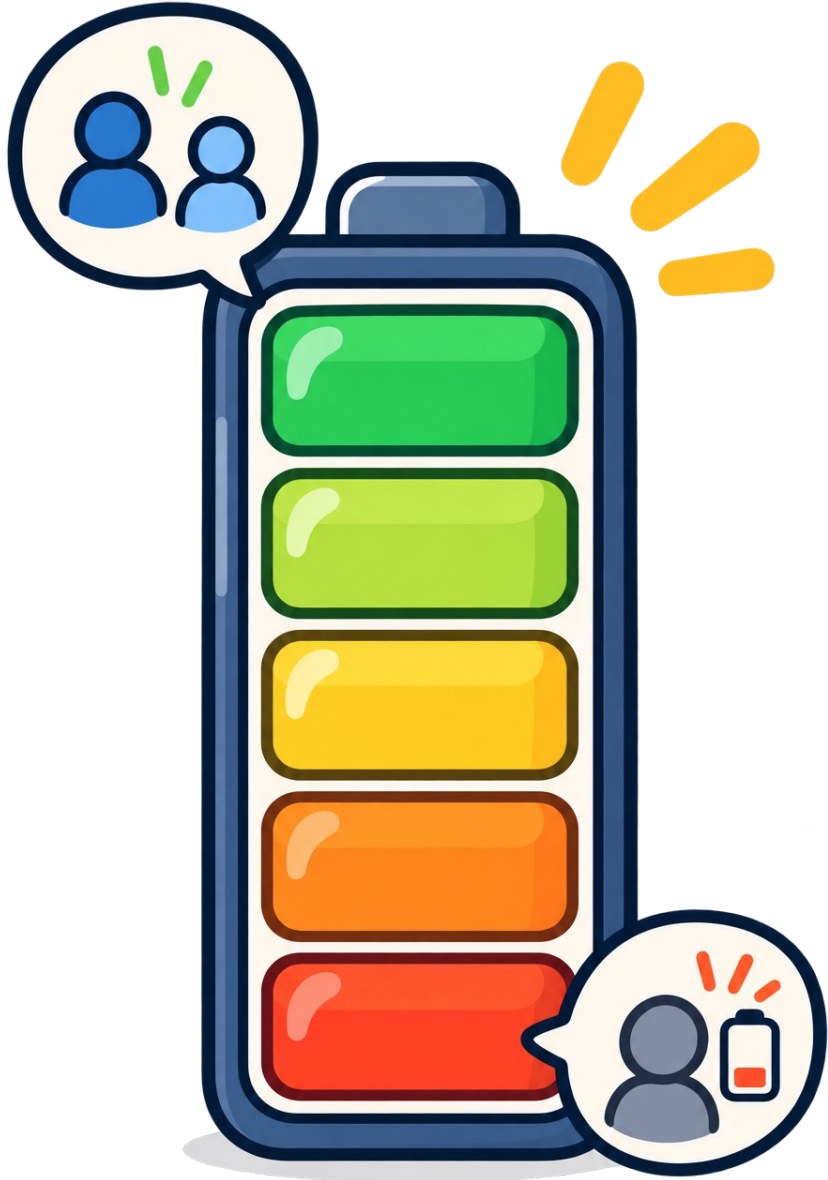


Discussion activity



- When do the students you have in mind seem most comfortable connecting with others at school?
- What kinds of connection does each of them enjoy?
(Talking, gaming, sport, making things, shared interests, being together quietly, online interaction?)
- Are there times in the school day when being social seems enjoyable, and times when it seems tiring or overwhelming?
- What can educators change to make social connection feel safer, easier or more meaningful?





Managing Daily Capacity

Batteries and Spoons

Think of a student's energy as a battery.

Every day starts with a charge amount, and it's not the same charge at the start of each day.

Every action uses up energy. When the battery runs low, the body will show it.



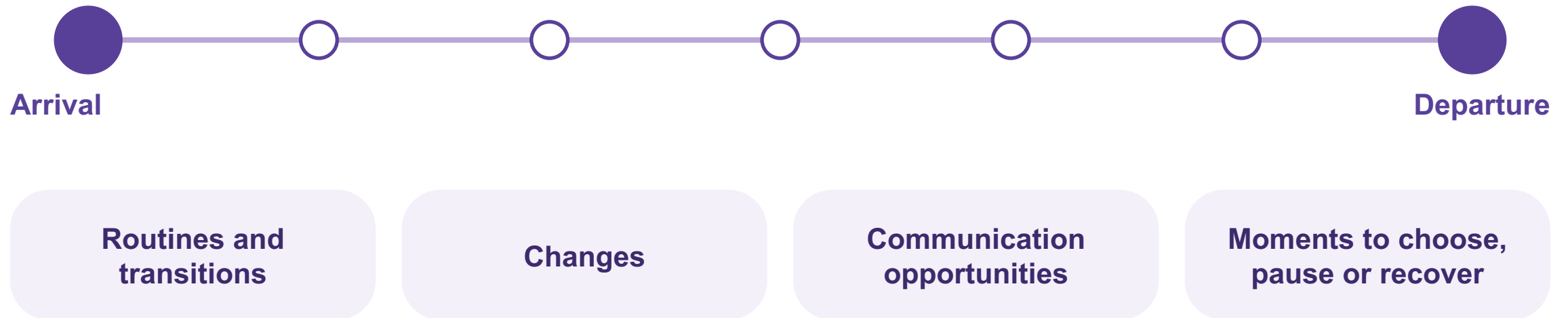
Fluctuating Capacity



Map a school day

Map a typical day in your classroom, from arrival to departure.

Draw a simple timeline, then add the moments that matter in your setting. If you don't have your own class yet, use a placement class or a class you know well.



What costs? What lightens?

Return to the day map.

Costs

What adds demand or uncertainty?

Lightens

What reduces demand?

What restores capacity or brings joy?

Where is a student's experience unknown?

Record questions rather than claiming to know an internal state.

The school-day stack

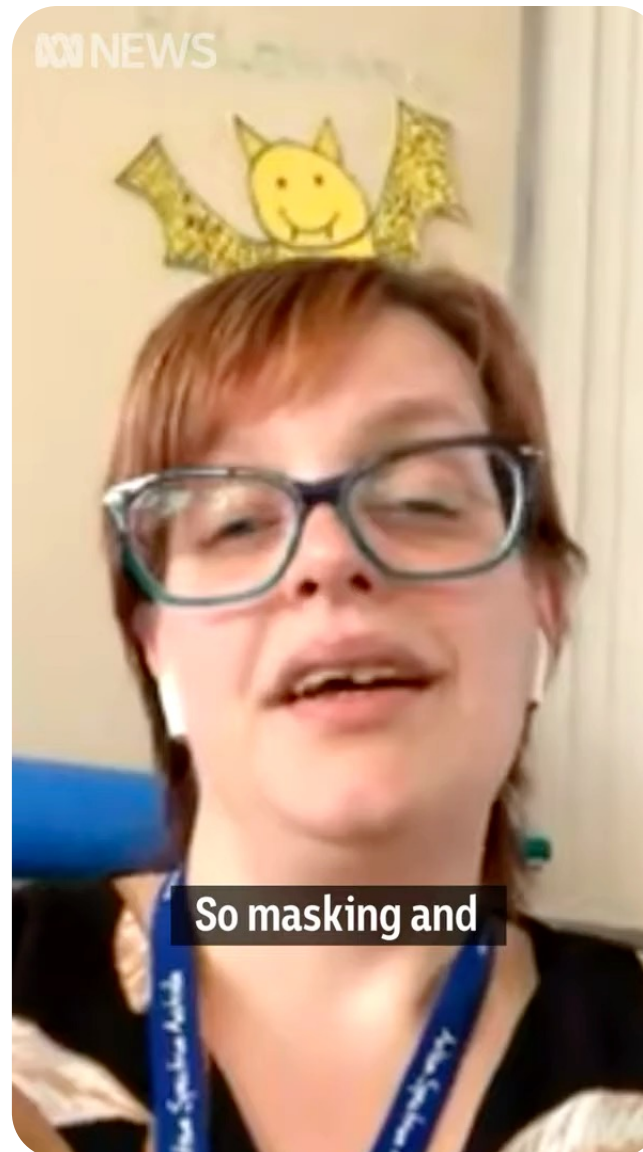
Notice what accumulates across the whole day.

A moment that seems small in isolation may sit within many demands. Include supports, relief and recovery as well as cost.





Masking



Masking and the cost of appearing fine



Discussion activity



- When might one of the students you have in mind be working hard to appear “fine” at school when they are not?
- When and where at school do they seem most comfortable being themselves?
- What could we change to help them feel more comfortable and supported?

You don't need all the answers

You need a way to find out and adjust. Notice what you see, keep your questions open, and know who to ask. If a strategy isn't working for a student, try a different one. That is part of teaching, not a failure.

Being new

You are still learning how this school works, and that is expected.

Learn how things work

Staffroom routines, who makes which decisions, and where to find information.

Hold your approach

Look at established practices without blaming the people who use them. Start with your own room.

Find your people

Most schools have colleagues who share this approach. Look for them early.

Ask questions

In your first years, questions are expected. Make good use of that.

Your own classroom is the best place to start.

Your support map

Before you need it, know who you will go to.

A student is distressed now

Who do you call or send for?

A worry is building

Who do you talk to when something has been on your mind for a few weeks?

You want advice

Who helps you think a situation through?

The formal supports

Wellbeing staff, learning support, your mentor, leaders, and the student and family.

Don't carry a worry about a student on your own. Map your supports in your Participant Guide.

When a student is distressed or you are worried

Know your school's pathway before you need it.

Who do you contact?

In the moment, and afterwards.

What process do you follow?

Your school has procedures for wellbeing and safety.

What will you bring?

Clear, factual information, without guessing at what the student was feeling.

Who can help next?

When the next step is unclear, ask your mentor or a leader.

Follow your school's procedures, and check them before you need them.

Positive Autistic Identity

A child who knows who they are -
and feels genuinely valued for it -
has more available for everything
else.

